The recommended dietary allowance (RDA) is the guideline stating the amount of nutrients to be actually consumed in order to meet the requirements of the body.

Evolution of Recommended Dietary Allowances (Indian Council of Medical Research- ICMR For Indian Population)

- Following the recommendations of the League of Nations in 1937, an attempt to recommend dietary allowances for energy, protein, iron,calcium, vitamin A, thiamine, ascorbic acid and vitamin D for Indians was made in 1944 by the Nutrition Advisory Committee of the Indian Research Fund Association, now called Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR).

- Between 1950 and 1968, in the wake of recommendations for energy and protein requirements by the Food and Agricultural Organization (FAO) and based on the international data provided by the FAO/ WHO expert groups and those available in India, the recommendations for dietary requirements were revised.

- A few years later, a newer set of data were generated by various researches and surveys conducted by renowned institutions like Avinashilingam Institute for Home Science and Higher Education for Women – Deemed University, Coimbatore, National Institute of Nutrition, Hyderabad.

- ICMR and National Nutrition Monitoring Bureau (NNMB), created a necessity to revise RDAs further. In 1988 an expert committee constituted by ICMR modified the reference body weight for Indian adults and RDAs in respect of energy fat, vitamin D and vitamin A. Recommendations on the safe intake of fat in terms of both visible and invisible dietary fats were made. For the first time, recommendations for certain trace elements, electrolytes (sodium and potassium), magnesium and phosphorus, vitamin K and vitamin E and dietary fibre were considered.

A number of approaches such as

- Dietary intake of nutrients
- Growth
- Nutrient balance
- Minimal loss of nutrients and
- Nutrient turnover

were utilized in arriving at the RDAs.

Difference between Requirement and Recommended Dietary Allowances

The requirement for a particular nutrient is the minimum level that needs to be consumed to perform specific functions in the body and to prevent deficiency symptoms. It should also maintain satisfactory stores of the nutrients in the body.

Requirements are the quantities of nutrients that healthy individuals must obtain from food to meet their physiological needs. The recommended dietary allowances (RDA) are estimates of nutrients to be consumed daily to ensure the requirements of all individuals in a given population. The recommended level depends upon the bioavailability of nutrients from a given diet. The term bioavailability indicates what is absorbed and utilized by the body. In addition, RDA includes a margin of safety, to cover variation between individuals, dietary traditions and practices

Recommended Dietary Allowances = Requirement +Margin of safety

The margin of safety is added to take care of factors such as

1. Losses during cooking and processing

2. Short periods of deficient intake

Unit 1 RECOMMENDED DIETARY ALLOWANCE AND MEAL PLANNING.indd 2 1/19/2020 2:50:59 PM